BOOKS

Those at the High Table

In a new book, restaurateur **Gauri Devidayal** chronicles the story of one of Mumbai's most acclaimed dining destinations



DIAMONDS FOR BREAKFAST
Cool Stories from Bombay's Hottest Kitchen
By Gauri Devidayal and Vishwas Kulkarni
AUTHORSUPFRONT
₹495; 152 pages

Those who know Mumbai know that a table at The Table has been a sign of having a seat at the table. It's the same as the snob value of belonging to the right school or having the right club membership. So, when we first heard about *Diamonds for Breakfast: Cool Stories from Bombay's Hottest Kitchen*, authored by restaurateur Gauri Devidayal (who, along with her husband Jay Yousuf, owns The Table, Mag Street Kitchen and Mag Street Café) and eminent journalist Vishwas Kulkarni, we knew this was a story we just had to read.

The book is slated as a tell-all tome that brings you the trials and triumphs of being a restaurateur in Mumbai. You get a sweeping view of Devidayal's life, from checking into heartbreak hotel to finding new love. The journey of how she and Yousuf mastered the hospitality business with no prior experience is fascinating.

Everything—from the chandelier you may have seen a hundred times over the years to their truffle fries—has a history. The manager and the head chef are like characters in a film, complete with a back story and an interesting persona, which have contributed to The Table's legendary success. The kitchen confidential goes into great depth and detail about a fire that once broke out and the wavering fortunes of an old faithful. Stories abound, some hilarious, some sad, each one a thread in the warp and weft of the colourful tapestry that makes The Table what it is. There are also parallel tales of their hit and miss with Miss T, another restaurant they had opened. The book also talks about how they coped during the Covid-19 pandemic, an account that's inspiring for everyone, not just restaurateurs.

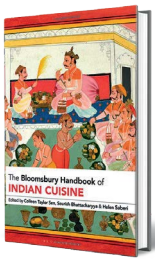
What it doesn't tell us could be a whole other book, though. We'd have

The book traces the fascinating history of The Table, but often meanders into unrelated musings and asides

FOOD FOR THOUGHT

Books on eating right, the history of Indian food and the current state of the country's culinary traditions

by Sharmistha Chaudhuri



THE BLOOMSBURY HANDBOOK OF INDIAN CUISINE
edited by Colleen Taylor Sen, Sourish Bhattacharyya & Helen Saberi
BLOOMSBURY **₹1,599; 448** pages

It might seem impossible to condense the essence of Indian cuisine into a single volume, but this ambitious guide does justice to the attempt. It seeks to detail the vast landscape riddled with diversities, regional practices, native and foreign ingredients, iconic dishes, communities, and topics that had previously been neglected in the mainstream. Separate entries also discuss the connections food has with medicine and worship. Apart from their own writing, the editors have also collaborated with prominent food experts in India.

